

Japan, *February 2027*

Three weeks across Tokyo, the mountains, Kyoto's old streets, and a snow week in Nozawa. Nine of us, three generations, one big birthday.

DATES	NIGHTS	OF US
2 — 25 Feb	23	9

The crew

Dad The 70-year-old	Mum	Gray
Sophie	Jess	Ben
Florence 9	Juniper 6	Goldie 2

The shape of the trip

Land late, ease in. A buffer for jetlag, body clocks, and the toddler. Big-city anchor experiences before we head into the mountains.

WHERE WE COULD STAY

MIMARU Tokyo Asakusa Station — apt-hotel, family suites with full kitchens, lift access. 3 min walk to Asakusa Station. [Property →](#) TBC

- Tue 2 TRAVEL Brisbane → Tokyo Narita, lands **17:30**. Transfer to hotel (~90 min). Conbini / hotel dinner — likely settled by 21:00.
- Wed 3 ANCHOR Morning: **Kappabashi-dori** kitchen town (knives, ceramics, plastic food samples). Afternoon: **Setsubun at Sensō-ji** — bean-throwing festival, oni costumes.
- Thu 4 ANCHOR Morning: **Tsukiji Outer Market** — sashimi breakfast, market wander. Afternoon: **Hama-rikyu Gardens** + tea house on the pond island.
- Fri 5 ANCHOR **Sumo morning practice** (6:30am, adult split-cohort, Ryōgoku). Afternoon: depachika browse (Mitsukoshi / Isetan). Early night before Hakone.

BONUS — IF YOU'VE GOT TIME

- STATIONERY **Itoya Ginza** — 13 floors of pens, washi, art supplies. Tokyo's stationery temple.
- KIDS **Pokemon Cafe + Pokemon Center DX (Nihonbashi)** — Pokemon HQ. Cafe needs ~1 month advance booking.
- CHAOS **Don Quijote (Akihabara or Shibuya)** — multi-floor discount megastore, snacks, weird stuff, tax-free.
- ARCHITECTURE **Sumida Hokusai Museum** — Kazuyo Sejima building + Hokusai prints. Pairs with Tsukiji morning.
- WHISKY **Bar Zoetrope (Shinjuku)** — 300+ Japanese whiskies, adult evening.
- NIGHTLIFE **Golden Gai (Shinjuku)** — six tiny alleys of 4–8 seat bars, adults only.
- HANDS-ON **Buaisou indigo workshop (Kuramae)** — traditional aizome dyeing, take a tote home.

Onsen town. Mt Fuji views, volcanic valleys, and the slow-down day before Kyoto.

WHERE WE COULD STAY

Hakone Ashinoko Hanaori — modern lakeside ryokan with private bookable onsens (tattoo-safe), Western-Japanese hybrid rooms (beds + chairs), lift access, family suites. [Property →](#) TBC

Sat 6

TRAVEL

Tokyo → Hakone on Odakyu Romancecar (~85 min). Lunch in Yumoto.
Afternoon: **Hakone Open-Air Museum**. Check in to ryokan, onsen + kaiseki dinner.

Sun 7

ANCHOR

The Hakone Loop — Tozan switchback railway → cable car → ropeway over Owakudani (volcanic valley, black eggs) → pirate ship across Lake Ashi (Fuji views) → Hakone Shrine (torii in the water) → bus back.

BONUS — IF YOU'VE GOT TIME

ART

Pola Museum of Art — Impressionists in a forest setting, walk-able from the ropeway.

PHOTOGENIC

Hakone Glass Forest (Venetian Glass Museum) — kid-friendly, very pretty.

The cultural heart and the depth leg. Eight nights to slow right down — temples, machiya streets, sake breweries, master craft. Wide day-trip range: Himeji, Nara, Fushimi sake, Yamazaki distillery, Osaka half-day, Kaiyukan aquarium.

WHERE WE COULD STAY

Ruikou Machiya (Machiya Residence Inn) — 4-bedroom heritage machiya, 184m², two buildings around a garden. Western beds + kitchen + dining for Mum and Dad in the detached hanare. Two kitchens.

[Property →](#) [ENQUIRY IN](#)

Backup: **Miyagawacho Samurai Machiya** (Gion-adjacent, 4–5 BR with multiple Western beds). [Property →](#)

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|--------|---------------|---|
| Mon 8 | TRAVEL | Hakone → Kyoto via shinkansen (~2 hr 15). Check in. |
| Tue 9 | ANCHOR | Higashiyama / Gion day — Kiyomizu-dera, Sannenzaka/Ninenzaka, Yasaka Shrine, Gion wander. Optional free walking tour in the morning. |
| Wed 10 | ANCHOR | Fushimi day — Inari shrine 1000 torii morning, Fushimi sake district afternoon (Gekkeikan museum + tasting, Kizakura). |
| Thu 11 | ANCHOR | Morning: Nara half-day — Tōdai-ji giant Buddha + deer park. Afternoon back in Kyoto. |
| Fri 12 | ANCHOR | Himeji Castle day trip (~50 min shinkansen). Keep climb + Koko-en gardens. Split-cohort if Goldie skips the keep. |
| Sat 13 | ANCHOR | Kids day — Toei Kyoto Studio Park (samurai film set, ninja shows, costume dress-up) + Kyoto Railway Museum. |
| Sun 14 | ANCHOR | Yamazaki + Kaiyukan day — split cohort, adults distillery / kids aquarium. |
| Mon 15 | FREE | Morning: forward bags to Nozawa via Yamato Takkyubin (arrives Tue). Afternoon: free / last Kyoto wander. |

BONUS — IF YOU'VE GOT TIME

FOOD **Nishiki Market** — "Kyoto's kitchen," covered food street, snack as you walk.

NIGHTLIFE **Pontocho alley** — narrow lantern-lit alley packed with restaurants and bars after dark.

FOOD **Kichi Kichi omurice** — theatrical chef-as-show omurice (the famous YouTube one). Book ahead.

CALENDAR GIFT **Plum blossom at Kitano Tenmangu** — ~1,500 plum trees in peak bloom mid-Feb. Plum tea house in the grounds.

CULTURE **Tea ceremony with a master** — proper sit-down, ~90 min. Operators: Camellia, En, Hozan-ji.

KIMONO **Kimono dress-up in Gion** — get dressed and photographed in old Kyoto streets.

BAMBOO **Arashiyama half-day** — bamboo grove + Tenryū-ji + Togetsukyo bridge. Skip the monkey park.

TEMPLE **Saiho-ji Moss Temple** — advance postal reservation only, sutra-copying meditation, otherworldly.

LEG 04 · 5 NIGHTS — LOCKED

Nozawa Onsen

Tue 16 — Sun 21 Feb

The snow week. Skiing for those who want it, 13 free public bathhouses, and Sparena for the lower-pressure mixed-bathing option. Nozawa Dream Central is the target accommodation.

WHERE WE COULD STAY

Nozawa Dream Central — chalet-style accommodation in the village, walking distance to lifts and public baths. [Property →](#) **ENQUIRY PENDING**

Tue 16 **TRAVEL** Kyoto → Tokyo → Iiyama → Nozawa (~5 hr door-to-door). Daypacks only — bags arrive separately. **9am Kyoto → ~2:30pm Nozawa**. Check in, onsen, settle.

Wed 17 **ANCHOR** **Ski day 1**. Girls in lessons. Non-skiers: village + Sparena + Sakaya Honten sake.

Thu 18 **ANCHOR** **Ski day 2**. Non-skiers optional **Nagano + Obuse** day-trip (Zenkō-ji, Hokusai Museum, Masuichi-Ichimura sake).

Fri 19 **ANCHOR** **Ski day 3**. Non-skiers: village + onsen + relaxed pace.

Sat 20 **FREE** **Chill day**. Onsen, Sparena, slow village wander, pack. Everyone wind-down.

Back to the city for the wind-down. The sushi-counter dinner. The slow re-pack.

WHERE WE COULD STAY

MIMARU Tokyo Asakusa Station (same as arrival) — apt-hotel, family suites with full kitchens, lift access. 3 min walk to Asakusa Station. [Property →](#) TBC

Alternate: **MIMARU Tokyo Shinjuku West** (swap neighbourhood for the wind-down). [Property →](#)

- Sun 21 TRAVEL Nozawa → Tokyo (~2.5–3 hr door-to-door). 9am Nozawa → ~12:30pm Tokyo. Daypacks only — bags forwarded Sat.
- Mon 22 ANCHOR **Dad's golf day** — Ginza morning (Honma + Mizuno flagships), Kanda Ogawamachi afternoon (Victoria Golf + sports street browse).
- Tue 23 ANCHOR Morning: **Ghibli Museum** (Mitaka — book tickets 10am JST on 10 Jan 2027). Evening: **Dad's birthday dinner** — sushi counter.
- Wed 24 ANCHOR **teamLab Planets** (Toyosu — barefoot water immersive) + **Small Worlds Tokyo** (Ariake — model city park, get inserted as figurines).

BONUS — IF YOU'VE GOT TIME

VIEW **Shibuya Sky** — 230m glass-edged open-air observation deck. Sunset is the play.

STATIONERY **Kakimori (Kuramae)** — make-your-own notebook + custom ink at Inkstand next door. Reddit favourite.

ART **Yayoi Kusama Museum** — Kusama deep dive. Lottery booking opens 2 months ahead.

DESIGN **21_21 Design Sight (Tadao Ando, Midtown)** — rotating design exhibitions.

WALK **Yanaka old-town** — quiet residential Tokyo, narrow lanes, less touristy.

SUB-CULTURE **Nakano Broadway** — multi-floor anime/manga/used goods. Mandarake flagship inside.

BEER **Yebisu Beer Museum** — small museum + tasting bar, dad-coded half-day.

● Travel day ● Anchor day ● Free day

Where we're at

LOCKED IN

Flights (Brisbane → Narita, 2 Feb 17:30)

Nozawa dates (16–21 Feb)

5-leg itinerary shape

Osaka cut — Yamazaki, Kaiyukan, Castle as Kyoto day-trips

OPEN THREADS

Nozawa Dream Central — confirm dates + breakfast

Accommodation per leg (9 of us)

Activity bookings (Yamazaki, sushi, etc.)

Share with the family group